

3.2 Child language acquisition

Paper 3 Language Analysis · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Analyse child language through phonology, lexis, grammar and pragmatics using the exact transcript. Overgeneralisation can reveal productive rule learning; a single utterance is weak evidence for a stage. Caregiver response, interaction and context matter. Compare explanatory models cautiously rather than treating one theory as universal.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A child says “I goed home”: the regular past-tense rule is applied to an irregular verb. It shows rule formation, not a lack of all grammatical understanding.

Original practice stimulus

Adult: “What did you see by the garden wall?” Child, age three: “Two mice came out, and one runned under the box.” Adult: “Two mice came out?” Child: “Yes, two mice. The little one runned fast.” Adult: “It ran fast.” Child: “It runned over there.” Later, pointing to a picture, the child says: “Those are mice in the book.” The exchange was recorded during a conversation at home and transcribed afterward by the adult. Pauses, gestures and the child's pronunciation were not recorded. A short sample cannot establish the child's use of these forms on other days.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Transcript: Child, age 3: "Two mice came." Adult: "Two mice?" Child: "Yes, two mice." Analyse the child's morphology and the adult's response. [25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong response explains plural overgeneralisation, child persistence, adult recast and limits of inference from a short exchange. Discusses evidence in linguistic terms, with cautious links to acquisition and interaction rather than diagnosing ability.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: English Language 9093, 2024–2026.
<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/635901-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.